Declaration of Independence

In Congress, July 4, 1776 · Thomas Jefferson, principal author

Source: U.S. National Archives, archives.gov/founding-docs/declaration-transcript

Adopted by the Second Continental Congress on July 4, 1776, the Declaration announced the thirteen colonies' break from Great Britain. It draws on Enlightenment political philosophy — especially John Locke's natural-rights theory — to justify revolution. The document is organized in three movements: a philosophical preamble, a long list of grievances against King George III, and a formal declaration of independence.

Connect: Locke's natural-rights theory shaped Jefferson's language. What Locke phrases appear almost word-for-word in the Preamble?

Key Passages

Preamble (natural rights)

> We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.

Right of revolution

> That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government, laying its foundation on such principles and organizing its powers in such form, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their Safety and Happiness.

Sample grievances

> He has refused his Assent to Laws, the most wholesome and necessary for the public good… He has kept among us, in times of peace, Standing Armies without the Consent of our legislatures… For imposing Taxes on us without our Consent: For depriving us in many cases, of the benefits of Trial by Jury…

The declaration itself

> We, therefore, the Representatives of the united States of America … solemnly publish and declare, That these United Colonies are, and of Right ought to be Free and Independent States.

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	After Lexington and Concord (1775), the failed Olive Branch Petition, and the spread of Paine's Common Sense, the Second Continental Congress voted for independence.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	King George III and Parliament, the colonists (to win support for independence), and foreign powers such as France whose help the colonies needed.
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Thomas Jefferson, a Virginia planter and enslaver drafting for Congress, using Enlightenment ideas from Locke; enslaved people, women, and Native peoples are left out of 'all men.'

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. Contextualization (DBQ/LEQ, 1 pt): Write one paragraph placing the Declaration in the broader Enlightenment / colonial-resistance context (1763–1776).

2. Identify TWO grievances and explain how each connects to a specific British policy after 1763.

3. How does Jefferson's phrase 'all men are created equal' square — or fail to square — with the practice of slavery in 1776?